rahe mera dil', a song personifying the endless optimism lovers harbour no matter what the circumstances. The Kishore-Lata combination catapulted this amazing song into a classic.

But what really pinned Indian music to the world map was the performance of M.S. Subbulakshmi at the UN General Assembly in 1966. Historic, iconic, you can use any adjective here, and it will still fall short in explaining how important this moment was for India and its music.

And like a classic flashback, we now reach the end where we talk about the beginning. An era where colours were unseen and music would shape the future. Released on Independence Day in 1957, *Naya Daur* remains one of the top 10 highest-grossing Indian films of all time. O.P. Nayyar literally introduced a *naya daur* of music with the timeless, percussion driven '*Ude jab jab zulfein teri*'. Penned by the brilliant Sahir Ludhianvi and sung by Rafi and a then relatively unknown Asha Bhosle, this song was the heart of the film. I wonder how Madhubala, who was initially cast as the lead, would have danced on this track. Nevertheless, Vyjayanthimala made this song her own. In incandescent acts elsewhere, Geeta Dutt mesmerised audiences with her hypnotic voice, Rafi Saab drove the voice of Shammi Kapoor on the silver screen, Satyajit Ray gave birth to the world-renowned *Pather Panchali* with its iconic theme music and Naushad composed the soundtrack of *Baiju Bawra* and introduced Hindustani classical music to the mainstream.

There are two other pivotal milestones from this era which for me are probably the most important pieces of Indian music history from the past 75 years. '*Mera joota hai Japani*', the song current younglings know from films such as *Deadpool* or *Gravity*, has some history that is even more compelling. The stars aligned, and brought together five unique individuals—Raj Kapoor, singer Mukesh, music director duo Shankar-Jaikishan and lyricist Shailendra. Never in the history of Indian music had such a super team been formed. It was the first Indian song to gain global popularity, all the way from the Soviet Union to the United States of America.

The second milestone is the discovery of Lata Mangeshkar. '*Aayega aanewaala*' still remains the song that defines Madhubala. Penned by Nakhshab Jarchavi and hauntingly composed by Khemchand Prakash, this song made Lata Mangeshkar a household name. And when she sang '*Aye mere watan ke logon*' against the backdrop of the Sino-Indian wWar, an entire nation cried. Lata Mangeskar is the true voice of this nation. History has been kind to Indian music. May the melodies never stop playing in our heads and in our lives. ■



A TOP 10 PLAYLIST

Dholida (Gangubai Kathiawadi, 2022)

Tum hi ho (Aashiqui 2, 2013)

Kaho naa pyar hai (Kaho Naa... Pyaar Hai, 2000)

Tujhe dekha toh yeh jaana sanam (DDLJ, 1995)

Dum maaro dum (Hare Rama Hare Krishna, 1971)

Yeh sham mastani (Kati Patang, 1971)

Gata rahe mera dil (Guide, 1965)

Uden jab jab zulfen teri (Naya Daur, 1957)

Mera joota hai japani (Awara, 1951)

Aayega aanewala (Mahal, 1949)

FROM '*TUM HI HO*' TO '*KESARIYA*', ARIJIT SINGH HAS CRAFTED MUSICAL TOUCHSTONES FOR THIS GENERATION